

2b. Core Content of A Level in Music (H543)

The following core content outlines the knowledge and understanding that underpin this qualification. The content will be assessed across all components. It should be used in conjunction with the Areas of Study. This qualification requires learners to develop an in-depth understanding of musical elements,

musical contexts and musical language, and apply these, where appropriate, to their own work when performing and composing. Further details of the skills needed for the Performing, Composing and Listening and appraising components are given in Sections 2c – 2g.

Musical elements and their interdependence	• organisation of pitch (melodically and harmonically) including: ◦ harmonic change ◦ cadences e.g. interrupted ◦ melodic and harmonic devices ◦ complex chord progressions e.g. the use of secondary dominant ◦ melodic devices such as augmentation • tonality including: ◦ how keys are related to each other e.g. circle of fifths ◦ complex and remote key relationships e.g. enharmonic • structure; organisation of musical material including: ◦ complex structures e.g. sonata form, fugue and through-composed music • sonority including: ◦ combinations of vocal timbres ◦ instrumental techniques e.g. con sordino, sul ponticello • texture including: ◦ complex combinations of musical lines (parts) e.g. homophony and polyphony ◦ and more complex applications of these e.g. fugue • tempo, metre and rhythm; how music is organised in time including: ◦ metrical and rhythmic devices e.g. changing metres and syncopation, additive rhythm and polyrhythms • dynamics; use of dynamics including: ◦ expressive devices e.g. contrast and extended ranges and refined control of dynamics and extreme ranges.
Musical contexts	• the effect of purpose and intention e.g. of the composer, performer, commissioner on how music is created, developed and performed in different historical, social and cultural contexts • the effect of audience, time and place e.g. venue, occasion on how music is created, developed and performed in different historical, social and cultural contexts • how music from different historical, social and cultural contexts has changed over time.

Musical language	• reading and writing staff notation including: ◦ rhythmic notation in compound time, irregular time signatures and all key signatures • chords and associated chord symbols including: ◦ standard harmonic progressions e.g. chord inversions and dominant 7th chords ◦ extended chords e.g. secondary 7ths and 9ths • musical vocabulary and terminology related to the Areas of Study including: ◦ recognition and use of appropriate musical vocabulary and terminology e.g. glissando, repetition and conjunct; recognition ◦ use of sophisticated terminology e.g. portamento, and ascending minor scale.
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Areas of Study

Learners will study at least four areas from a choice of six Areas of Study. Learners will study Areas of Study 1 and 2 and a choice of at least two more from Areas of Study 3, 4, 5 and 6.

Through the investigation and in-depth study of the large variety of music contained in the six Areas of Study set for A Level Music, learners will further develop their knowledge and understanding of:

- the musical elements and their interdependence
- musical contexts
- musical language.

The purpose of the Areas of Study is to provide contexts through which learners will study the core content of A Level Music and explore the three key inter-related elements of:

- tonality
- interpretation
- instrumental/vocal techniques.

They are designed to encourage a musical and practical approach to teaching and learning, and to promote integration between the skills of performing, composing and appraising (listening).

The Areas of Study have been designed to be flexible to allow centres and learners to tailor the course of study to their own preferences. The centre may choose which Areas of Study to follow based on learner choice, learner ability, or teacher preference. The table below gives examples of how the Areas of Study can be combined.

	Performing	Composing	Listening and appraising	Areas of Study covered
Example 1	Learner has free choice - applies knowledge of skills, techniques and interpretation to free performance choices.	Learner studies Area of Study 2 and chooses composition brief related to Area of Study 2 .	Area of Study 1 and 2 compulsory. Learner studies and chooses questions related to Area of Study 3 and Area of Study 4 .	1, 2, 3 & 4
Example 2	Learner chooses a recital programme related to Area of Study 6 .	Learner studies Area of Study 6 and chooses composition brief related to Area of Study 6 .	Area of Study 1 and 2 compulsory. Learner studies and chooses questions related to Area of Study 3 and 6 .	1, 2, 3 & 6

Area of Study 1: Instrumental Music of Haydn, Mozart and Beethoven

Outline	Learners should study in depth the development of Classical instrumental music as found in the instrumental works of Haydn, Mozart and Beethoven: • use attentive listening and contextual knowledge to analyse, evaluate and make critical judgements about the repertoire • use technical vocabulary to communicate a sophisticated understanding of music and its context. This includes but is not limited to: • Chamber Music • Symphony • Concerto • Sonata. A prescribed work from this Area of Study will be part of the focus for study although learners should understand about the context and development of the music around the prescribed work.
Focus for learning	Learners should analyse, explain and compare developments in instrumental style, including: • the characteristics and principles of instrumental music in the Classical period • the forms and style of the Classical period as found in the music of Haydn, Mozart and Beethoven. Learners should study and understand how classical composers use musical elements, including: • the orchestra and instruments of the Classical period • the use of instrumental techniques including articulation • instrumentation and texture • techniques of melodic construction • the use of harmonic language including inversions, cadences and harmonic progressions • phrasing and structure • musical vocabulary and terminology related to instrumental music e.g Harmonic change and melodic and harmonic devices • dynamics and expressive devices. Learners should study and understand the conditions and context in which Classical instrumental music was created and performed, including: • the historical and social context of the music of the Classical period • the effect of purpose and intention on how music is created and developed • the reading and writing of associated staff notation • working conditions for musicians.